The Ranking Transfers, the Threshold Does Not: Early At-Risk Prediction in Unseen Courses

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***Abstract*—Early-warning systems for online higher education are usually evaluated on random splits that place the same courses in training and test sets, often with features computed over the whole course. Before such a system is used in a course it has never seen, two questions matter: how much signal is available early, and which parts of the model's behaviour survive the change of course. We study both on the Open University Learning Analytics Dataset (OULAD; 32,593 enrolments in 7 modules of one distance-learning university), predicting an unfavourable outcome—withdrawal or failure—from the first 10–50% of each presentation, and holding out one module at a time with no student on both sides of the split. An audit first shows that three common choices more than double the apparent transfer gap (0.033 versus 0.014). We then separate ranking, alert volume and calibration. Ranking largely transfers (mean AUC cost 0.014 [0.010, 0.017] at 25% of the course), but the alert volume and the calibration do not: in one module the share of flagged students rises from 44% to 95% for an observed risk of 37%, at every threshold from 0.3 to 0.7. Signed SHAP attributions show that the transferred model uses the same features as local models but reads them on absolute scales—engagement volumes, formative scores—whose meaning depends on course design. Normalizing these features within the cohort at prediction time, which needs no labels, changes the mean absolute flag-rate drift by −0.115 [−0.120, −0.107] and the AUC on unseen modules by +0.021 [+0.015, +0.027], gains that are not uniform across modules. Percentile ranks work best, any cohort normalization captures most of the gain, and cohorts of about 50 students suffice. Gradient boosting and a recurrent network on weekly sequences show the same drift. Finally, the drift turns into a gender disparity through course composition; cohort normalization strongly attenuates it. These results hold across the modules of one university; transfer across institutions remains to be tested.**

***Index Terms*—Learning analytics, at-risk prediction, dropout, early warning systems, transferability, dataset shift, calibration, SHAP, algorithmic fairness, OULAD.**

I. Introduction

DROPOUT and failure remain major obstacles to the promise of online higher education. Learning management systems (LMS) record student activity from the first day of a course, which has made data-driven early-warning systems an attractive way to target support while there is still time to act. The Open University Learning Analytics Dataset (OULAD) [1] has become the reference benchmark for this task: it is open, large, and combines demographics, registration, virtual learning environment (VLE) clickstreams and assessments for 22 module presentations. A recent systematic review counts a steady stream of predictive studies built on it [2].

High accuracy on OULAD is no longer informative in itself. Two limitations recur in the recent literature and both matter when a model is to be used elsewhere. First, many studies compute predictors over the whole presentation; a 2026 regional fairness audit notes that its design is retrospective and that several of its predictors span the whole presentation [3]. Such models cannot inform intervention, which must happen early. Second, models are almost always evaluated on splits that keep the same courses on both sides. A 2026 study predicting learner outcomes from the first 25% of each presentation names its single-institution scope as a limit to external generalization [4]; a calibrated early-warning study on OULAD splits by course presentation, so other presentations of a test module can still appear in training [5]. Outside OULAD, the evidence that predictive models are course-specific is strong [6]–[8], yet the mechanism of the failure is rarely examined.

This gap is concrete for institutions that would deploy an early-warning system without a labelled history of their own, such as the authors' fully online university in Senegal, where the target courses differ from any training course in design, assessment calendar and population. The relevant question is not whether a model achieves a high AUC on held-out students of known courses, but what part of its behaviour survives the move to a course it has never seen, why, and what can be done before labels exist.

We address this question on OULAD with an evaluation that is strict about timing and context. Predictions use only data available at a cut-off day placed at 10–50% of each presentation, and we compare a random split grouped by student, protocol (A), with leave-one-module-out, protocol (B), in which each module plays the role of an unseen course and no student is on both sides of the split. Our contributions are:

1) *A methodological audit.* Three choices common in OULAD pipelines inflate early performance and the apparent transfer gap: keeping students already withdrawn at the cut-off (19.5% of enrolments at 25%), using scores submitted after the cut-off, and comparing a pooled AUC in (A) with a per-module mean in (B). Corrected, the transfer gap falls from 0.033 to 0.014 (Table I).
2) *A decomposition of transfer.* We separate intrinsic module difficulty, the transfer cost on ranking, and the drift of alert volume and calibration. Ranking largely transfers; alert volume and calibration do not, whatever the threshold; and the modules that look hardest are difficult rather than untransferable (Sections IV-C and IV-D).
3) *A mechanism.* A transferred-versus-local SHAP comparison and a decomposition of the drift into signed attributions show that the transferred model relies on the same features as local ones but reads them on absolute scales whose meaning depends on course design. Global

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|SHAP| importance cannot reveal this (Section IV-F).

4) *A label-free remedy and its conditions.* Normalizing engagement and early-assessment features within the cohort at prediction time reduces the drift and improves ranking on average; we compare it, on the same students, with Platt recalibration on labelled students and with flagging a fixed share of each cohort, and we identify the normalization and the cohort size it requires (Sections IV-G and IV-H).
5) *A fairness consequence.* Drift across courses converts into a gender disparity through course composition, which pooled audits read as discrimination and within-course audits do not; disparities linked to deprivation, in contrast, are present within courses (Section IV-J).
6) *Independence from the learner.* Gradient boosting and a recurrent network on weekly activity sequences reproduce the same drift and the same correction, and the temporal signal adds little to early prediction (Section IV-K).

We distinguish three levels of claims. Our experiments establish the gains of cohort normalization on the seven modules studied, and support the interpretation that it reduces the sensitivity of a model to course design. Whether this carries over to other institutions and countries, which motivates this work, is a hypothesis that the present data cannot test.

II. Related Work

A. Early prediction on OULAD

OULAD was released to support the at-risk prediction work of the Open University [1]. Studies have since varied the observation window, for instance predicting at several percentages of the course length [9], or from the first 25% of each presentation with deep architectures [4]. Wu et al. [5] use a 28-day window, calibrate a gradient-boosting model, and audit subgroup fairness and alert capacity; their split holds out course presentations, not modules. Hlosta et al. [10] address a related cold-start problem at the Open University by training on the running presentation itself rather than on legacy data. We complement these studies by holding out entire modules and by asking which parts of the model's behaviour survive.

B. Portability of predictive models across courses

The Open Academic Analytics Initiative showed that a model trained at one institution could be ported to others with moderate loss [11]. Course-level analyses are less optimistic: Gašević et al. [6] found that the predictive value of LMS indicators depends on instructional conditions, Conijn et al. [7] that models varied substantially across 17 courses of a single institution, and López-Zambrano et al. [8] that direct transfer between Moodle courses works only under some conditions. Riestra-González et al. [12] built course-agnostic early predictors from massive LMS logs, and Boyer and Veeramachaneni [13] studied transfer learning across MOOC offerings. These works measure whether accuracy transfers; we decompose *what* fails to transfer and why.

C. Dataset shift, calibration and normalization

A change of context is a case of dataset shift, in which covariate, prior or concept changes can affect a classifier [14]. In clinical prediction, it is well established that discrimination often survives a change of setting while calibration does not, and that simple updating of the intercept or slope on local data restores much of it [15], [16]. Platt scaling [17] is the corresponding tool for machine-learning classifiers. Without labels, domain adaptation methods re-estimate normalization statistics on the target domain [18] or adapt a model at test time from unlabelled target data [19]. Normalizing features within a cohort is a simple, model-agnostic instance of this idea, and we do not claim it as a new technique. Our contribution is to show why it is needed for early-warning features, what it corrects and what it does not, and under which conditions it works.

D. Fairness of predictive student models

Fairness audits of student models compare error rates and alert rates across demographic groups [20], [21]. On OULAD, recent studies document accuracy–fairness trade-offs [22], regional disparities in recall [3] and policy-dependent alert-rate gaps [5]. When base rates differ between groups, error-rate parity and calibration cannot all hold [23], [24]; equal opportunity [25] focuses on true-positive rates. We add a structural observation: aggregating over contexts can create group disparities that exist in no context, an instance of Simpson's paradox [26].

III. Data and Methods

A. Dataset and target

OULAD [1] (CC-BY 4.0) contains 32,593 enrolments in 22 presentations of 7 modules (AAA–GGG) at the Open University, UK. Each enrolment has a final result among Distinction, Pass, Fail and Withdrawn. Our main target is a composite unfavourable outcome, $y = 1$ for Withdrawn or Fail (52.8% of enrolments), since both call for the same early support; Section IV-L repeats the analyses with Withdrawn only.

B. Early window, population and features

For a presentation p of length L_p days, the cut-off day is $d_c = \mathrm{round}(c\,L_p)$ with $c \in \{0.10, 0.20, 0.25, 0.33, 0.50\}$; $c = 0.25$ is the reference. The population at d_c consists of the students registered on or before d_c and not unregistered by d_c. Students who have already left cannot be helped by an early warning, and keeping them makes the task artificially easy (Section IV-A).

For each enrolment we compute eighteen predictors from data dated on or before d_c: *demographics* (gender, region, highest education, IMD band, age band, previous attempts, studied credits, disability); *registration* (registration date relative to the course start and days registered in advance); *VLE engagement* (total clicks, active days, distinct resources, first and last active day, clicks per active day); *early assessments* (number of assessments, and mean score of those, whose

deadline *and* submission both fall on or before d_c). Missing engagement is coded as zero activity, missing first and last active days by out-of-range sentinels, and a missing early score as -1.

Leakage control: Beyond excluding the final result and the unregistration date from the predictors [27], we test the whole pipeline by invariance: removing every raw record dated after d_c (clicks, submissions, deadlines, unregistrations) must leave the feature table unchanged. The test detects, for instance, a filter on assessment deadlines alone, which lets late submissions through (4.0% of the retained submissions at $c = 0.25$).

C. Absolute and cohort-normalized features

The *absolute* feature set uses the values above, as is usual. The *relative* set, our main model, replaces the eight engagement and early-assessment features by their percentile rank within the presentation,

$$\tilde{x}_{ij} = \frac{1}{n_p}\Big(L_{ij} + \frac{E_{ij}+1}{2}\Big), \tag{1}$$

where P_p is the population of presentation p at d_c, $n_p = |P_p|$, L_{ij} counts the students of P_p whose value of feature j is lower than x_{ij}, and E_{ij} those, i included, whose value equals it (average rank for ties). Demographic and registration features are unchanged. The transformation uses no labels, only unlabelled data of the target cohort available at the cut-off, and it passes the invariance test. To test whether ranks specifically are needed, we compare them with two other within-cohort normalizations of the same features: a z-score after winsorizing at the 1st and 99th percentiles of the cohort (sentinel values would otherwise dominate the scale), and a robust standardization by the median and the interquartile range. To assess the cohort size the ranks require, we recompute them in the target module within random sub-cohorts of $n \in \{10, 20, 50, 100, 200\}$ students (five random partitions), leaving the trained model unchanged.

D. Model and protocols

We use a random forest [28] of 300 trees with balanced class weights (scikit-learn [29], one-hot encoding of categorical variables, seed 0) and flag a student when the predicted probability $\hat{p} \geq 0.5$. Protocol (A) is a five-fold split stratified on y and grouped by student, so that no student appears in both training and test folds; its out-of-fold predictions cover every enrolment. Protocol (B) trains on six modules and predicts the seventh, for each module in turn. Since 6.8% of students are enrolled in several modules (up to 48.7% of the students of CCC also appear in another module), (B) is *strict*: students enrolled in the held-out module are removed from the training modules, so that, as in (A), no student is on both sides. The standard variant, which keeps them, serves as a robustness check (Section IV-I).

Both protocols are summarized in the same way: metrics are computed on the students of each module, then averaged over modules. An AUC pooled over all modules in (A) would reward the model for separating modules with different base rates, which (B) cannot do by construction.

For each module m we define three quantities on the same students:

$$\text{difficulty:} \quad D_m = \mathrm{AUC}_A(m), \tag{2}$$

$$\text{ranking cost:} \quad C_m = \mathrm{AUC}_A(m) - \mathrm{AUC}_B(m), \tag{3}$$

$$\text{flag-rate drift:} \quad \Delta_m = \bar{f}_B(m) - \bar{f}_A(m), \tag{4}$$

where $\bar{f}(m)$ is the share of the module's students flagged. D_m measures how predictable a module is when the model has seen it, C_m how much ranking is lost when it has not, and Δ_m how far the volume of alerts moves.

E. Calibration and threshold

Because a fixed threshold applied to probabilities learned with class weights does not by itself guarantee calibration, we also report calibration metrics per module for (A) and (B): the Brier score, the mean predicted risk, the calibration-in-the-large (intercept of a logistic regression of y with $\mathrm{logit}(\hat{p})$ as offset) and the calibration slope. With balanced weights the probabilities are not calibrated even in (A); the effect of transfer is the difference (B) $-$ (A) on the same students. We repeat the drift at thresholds 0.3 to 0.7, and report a threshold-free version, the difference in mean predicted risk.

F. Uncertainty

Confidence intervals (95%) come from a cluster bootstrap over students with 1,000 resamples [30]. Resampling students rather than enrolments respects the dependence between the enrolments of a student in several modules. The same resamples are used for all configurations, which gives paired intervals for differences between feature sets and protocols. These intervals reflect the sampling of students, not the choice of the seven modules: at the module level, we report how many modules improve and a paired Wilcoxon signed-rank test ($n = 7$). Finally, we rerun both protocols with 10 seeds to measure the variability due to the forest and the fold assignment.

G. Sequential features and alternative learners

To test whether temporal information or another learner changes the picture, we build weekly sequences over the K complete weeks observed before the cut-off in *every* presentation, $K = \lfloor(\min_p d_c + 1)/7\rfloor$ (3, 6, 8, 11 and 16 weeks for the five cut-offs), so that all sequences have the same length and use only data dated on or before d_c. Each week has two channels, clicks and active days; we add pre-course clicks and four trend features (slope of $\log(1 + \text{clicks})$ over the weeks, share of clicks in the second half of the window, number of active weeks, weeks since the last active one). In the relative variant these columns are also ranked within the presentation. They pass the invariance test.

We compare the random forest with three models: histogram gradient boosting (scikit-learn, balanced class weights) on the aggregated features, the same with the sequences and trends added, and a gated recurrent unit (GRU) network. The GRU reads the two-channel weekly sequence (hidden size 32); a dense layer encodes the static features (aggregated features, trends, demographics); both are concatenated before a logistic

output. It is trained with Adam (learning rate 2×10^{-3}, batches of 256, at most 30 epochs) on a loss weighted by the inverse class frequencies, so that the 0.5 threshold has the same meaning as for the forest, with early stopping on a stratified 10% split of the training data. All models are evaluated with protocols (A) and (B) as above.

H. Remedies

We compare four rules for flagging the students of a held-out module: the raw transferred model with absolute features; *Platt recalibration* [17] of that model, a logistic regression of y on $\mathrm{logit}(\hat{p}_B)$ with balanced weights, fitted on labelled students of the target module; *top-q*, which flags in each cohort the share q of students with the highest scores, q being the at-risk rate of the six training modules; and the *relative* model at threshold 0.5. Only Platt uses labels of the target module. For a fair comparison, all rules are evaluated on the same students and against the same reference: either (i) $k = 100$ students drawn at random are used by Platt (50 draws) and all rules are evaluated on the remaining students, or (ii) the first presentation of the module serves as a labelled pilot cohort and all rules are evaluated on the later presentations. The reference is the absolute-feature model trained with the module seen, (A); since that model itself flags more students than are at risk in some modules, we also report the distance between the share flagged and the observed at-risk rate, which does not depend on any reference model. A top-q rule using the true at-risk rate of the module gives an unreachable bound.

I. Context descriptors

To explain heterogeneity, each module and presentation is described by its assessment structure (number of assessments due before the cut-off, first non-exam deadline as a fraction of the presentation, share of the exam in the total weight), observable engagement (share of students with an early score, median clicks, number of VLE activity types) and population (size, at-risk rate, share of Withdrawn among at-risk students, share without A-levels, share aged 35 or more), plus the standardized distance of the assessment structure to that of the other modules. We report Spearman correlations with D_m, C_m and Δ_m at the module level ($n = 7$) and the presentation level ($n = 22$; presentations of a module share its LOMO model and are not independent), with Benjamini–Hochberg control of the false discovery rate within level [31].

J. Interpretability

We compute SHAP values [32] with TreeSHAP [33] for two models per module m: the *transferred* LOMO model, and a *local* model trained on m alone with two-fold cross-fitting grouped by student (each half is explained by the model trained on the other). Attributions of one-hot columns are summed back to their original variable. Exact TreeSHAP on unpruned forests is slow (about 1.7 s per student for 300 trees); since the SHAP value of a forest is the average of those of its trees, we estimate it without bias from 100 trees drawn at random, which reproduces the exact importance ranking with Spearman $\rho = 0.985$. We explain 400 students per module.

TABLE I
METHODOLOGICAL AUDIT AT THE 25% CUT-OFF (RANDOM FOREST). EACH ROW ADDS ONE CORRECTION TO THE PREVIOUS ONE. AUC OF PROTOCOL (A), RANDOM SPLIT GROUPED BY STUDENT, AND (B), LEAVE-ONE-MODULE-OUT (LOMO), MEAN OVER HELD-OUT MODULES.

Evaluation setting	AUC (A)	AUC (B)	Gap
1) Reference protocol (all enrolments, pooled AUC in (A))	0.882	0.848	0.033
2) + early scores filtered on submission date	0.880	0.847	0.033
3) + students still enrolled at the cut-off only	0.815	0.787	0.028
4) + same aggregation in (A) and (B)	0.800	0.787	0.014
5) + context-relative features	0.816	0.808	0.008

Two analyses follow. The *agreement* between transferred and local models is the Spearman correlation of their global importances (mean $|\phi|$) over the 18 variables. The *drift decomposition* averages signed attributions of the transferred model over the students of m and over feature families G:

$$\bar{\phi}_{m,G} = \frac{1}{|S_m|} \sum_{i \in S_m} \sum_{j \in G} \phi_{ij}. \tag{5}$$

By local accuracy, the sum over all families equals the mean difference between the predicted risk of m's students and the average prediction on the training modules.

K. Fairness

We compare true-positive rate (TPR), false-positive rate (FPR), precision (PPV) and flag rate between women and men, the most and least deprived IMD quintiles (Q1: 0–20%; Q5: 80–100%), and students with and without a declared disability, with the cluster bootstrap described above. Gaps are computed over all modules and within each module, with the group sizes (total, positive and negative cases) of each module, so that a pooled gap due to course composition can be told apart from a gap present within courses. These are descriptive associations: they do not identify the causes of a disparity.

L. Implementation and reproducibility

All analyses run in Python 3.12 with scikit-learn 1.9.1, pandas 3.0.6, shap 0.54.1 and PyTorch 2.14.1 (CPU), with fixed seeds. A single script regenerates every figure, table and number of this article from the raw OULAD files, and an automated test suite checks the absence of temporal leakage and that no student is on both sides of either protocol.

IV. RESULTS

A. Methodological audit

The reference pipeline we started from, which keeps all enrolments and compares a pooled AUC in (A) with a per-module mean in (B), gives AUC 0.882 in (A) and 0.848 in (B) at 25% of the course, a transfer gap of 0.033 (Table I). Filtering early scores on their submission date changes little. Restricting the population to students still enrolled at the cut-off has the largest effect: at 25%, 19.5% of enrolments have already ended, 62.5% of all Withdrawn outcomes among them,

including 2,678 unregistrations before the course started. Their last active day makes them trivial to predict, and their share ranges from 5.4% (GGG) to 28.0% (CCC), which confounds any comparison between modules. Finally, comparing like with like halves the gap again, from 0.028 to 0.014. Together, these choices make the apparent transfer gap more than twice its corrected value. Cohort-normalized features reduce it further to 0.008.

B. How early can we predict?

Fig. 1 shows performance against the length of the observed window. With relative features, AUC rises from 0.749 at 10% of the course to 0.878 at 50% in (A), and from 0.739 to 0.871 in (B); the gap between protocols stays between 0.007 and 0.010 at every cut-off (0.012–0.017 with absolute features). With absolute features, the transferred model flags too many students: at 25%, its recall exceeds that of (A) (0.719 versus 0.649) while its precision falls (0.618 versus 0.669). With relative features, recall and precision of (B) track those of (A) (0.649 versus 0.648; 0.680 versus 0.697). Reporting recall alone, a common practice for at-risk prediction, would have made the transferred model look better than the local one.

C. The ranking transfers, the alert volume does not

Table III and Fig. 2 separate the three quantities per module at 25%. The ranking cost is small: 0.014 [0.010, 0.017] on average with absolute features, and below 0.015 for 6 modules out of seven; BBB is the exception (0.043). Modules AAA and GGG, which a naive reading of LOMO results would call "poorly transferable", are in fact *difficult*: their AUC is already low when the model has seen them (0.733 and 0.739), and it drops by only 0.002 and 0.014 when it has not.

The volume of alerts is another matter. In GGG, the transferred model flags 95% of students, against 44% for the model that has seen the module and an observed risk of 37%: recall climbs from 0.66 to 0.99 and precision falls from 0.55 to 0.38. BBB drifts too (+0.19), CCC and DDD slightly downwards. The mean absolute drift is 0.135 [0.130, 0.141]. An institution that deployed such a model in a GGG-like course would contact almost every student.

D. A calibration problem, not only a threshold

A drift in alert volume at a fixed threshold could, in principle, come from the choice of the threshold alone. It does not. With absolute features, the mean drift stays between 0.084 and 0.138 for every threshold from 0.3 to 0.7, and between +0.16 and +0.60 for GGG; the threshold-free shift in mean predicted risk is 0.075 on average and +0.30 for GGG. The calibration metrics agree (Table IV): moving to an unseen module changes the Brier score by 0.039 on average (+0.180 for GGG) and the calibration-in-the-large by 0.42 (-1.83 for GGG), and the calibration slope of GGG by -0.321. With relative features, these differences shrink to 0.006, 0.08 and 0.077 on average, and the drift stays between 0.017 and 0.032 at all thresholds. The transferred absolute model is therefore miscalibrated on unseen modules in the strict sense, not merely thresholded at an unlucky value.

E. Why GGG drifts

Table II shows how GGG differs from the other modules. Its first non-exam assessment falls at about a quarter of the presentation instead of 7–13%, its assignments are formative (the exam carries the whole weight), and only half of its students have an early score at the cut-off. Its students also use the VLE much less: their median click count before the cut-off is 81 against 432 in the other modules, the 11th percentile of the latter. Elsewhere, students with at most 81 clicks are at risk in 79% of cases; in GGG, 47%. Elsewhere, a student without an early score is at risk in 98% of cases; in GGG, where 47% of students have none yet, 51%. Early scores are also lower (median 69 against 79). The drift is not limited to the period before the first deadline: it reaches +0.60 at 33% and +0.51 at 50% of the course.

In short, the model has learned absolute thresholds—"few clicks" or "no score yet" means risk—whose meaning depends on the design of the course. Table V gives the associations that survive multiple-testing control. Difficulty is associated with the share of older students (Spearman $\rho = -0.96$ over modules, -0.79 over presentations). Drift is larger where at-risk students fail rather than withdraw ($\rho = -0.68$), where students are older and less qualified, and where the VLE is used less. The structural distance of the assessment design to the other modules is associated with drift, not with the ranking cost, which is weakly associated with an earlier and denser assessment calendar. With seven modules, these associations are exploratory; the experiments below test the mechanism directly.

F. Interpretability: same features, wrong scales

If transfer failed because different features matter in different modules, global importances would differ between transferred and local models. They mostly do not. Local models rank the 18 variables similarly across modules (mean pairwise Spearman 0.81), with the mean early score first everywhere. Agreement between transferred and local importances is moderate with absolute features (mean 0.60, 3.3 of the top five variables in common) and higher with relative features (0.81, 4.3 in common), an improvement in 6 modules out of seven (Fig. 3a). Crucially, GGG—the module that drifts most—shows one of the *highest* agreements with absolute features (0.81). Its problem is not which features are used but how they are read.

The drift decomposition of Eq. (5) makes this visible (Fig. 3b). On GGG's students, the transferred absolute model raises predicted risk by +0.30 above its training average: +0.19 from early-score features and +0.12 from engagement, while demographics contribute -0.01. Across modules, this total follows the flag-rate drift ($\rho = 0.71$). With relative features the decomposition vanishes (-0.04 for GGG; Fig. 3c). Global importance, which discards the sign of attributions, cannot detect a calibration problem; signed attributions on the target population can.

G. Remedies compared on the same students

Table VI and Fig. 2c compare the four rules on the same students and against the same reference. Platt recalibration on

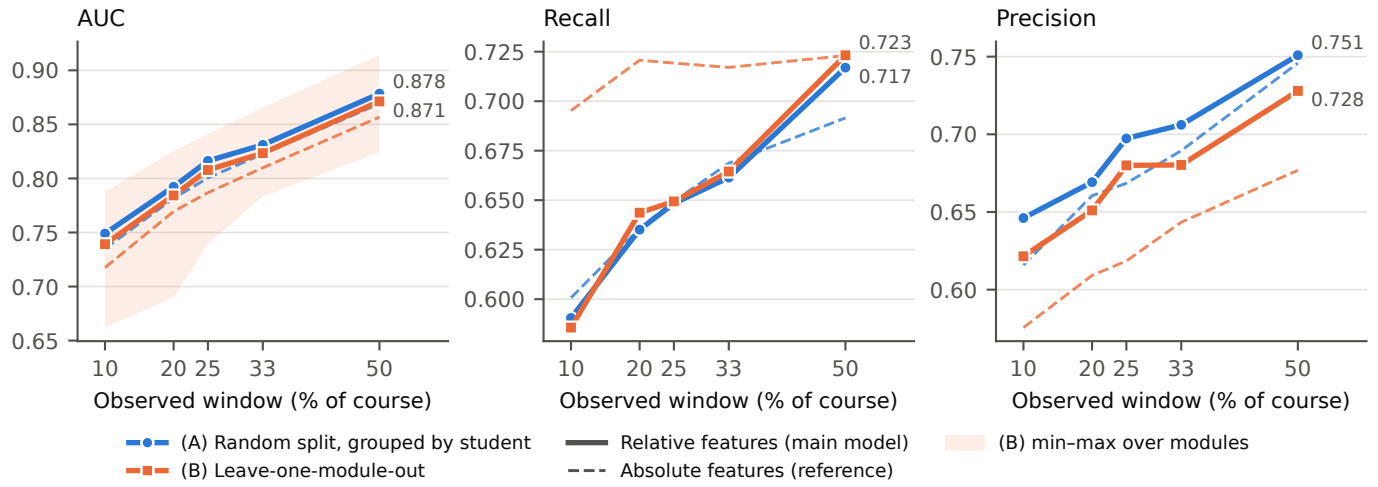


Fig. 1. Performance against the observed share of the presentation (students still enrolled at the cut-off). Solid lines: relative features; dashed lines: absolute features. Both protocols are averaged over modules in the same way; the band shows the range over held-out modules in (B) with relative features.

TABLE II

MODULE CHARACTERISTICS AT THE 25% CUT-OFF, STUDENTS STILL ENROLLED AT THE CUT-OFF. AT-RISK: WITHDRAWN OR FAIL. FIRST DEADLINE: FIRST NON-EXAM ASSESSMENT, AS A FRACTION OF THE PRESENTATION LENGTH. EXAM WEIGHT: SHARE OF THE EXAM IN THE TOTAL ASSESSMENT WEIGHT. EARLY SCORE: SHARE OF STUDENTS WITH AT LEAST ONE ASSESSMENT SUBMITTED BEFORE THE CUT-OFF. VALUES ARE AVERAGED OVER THE PRESENTATIONS OF EACH MODULE.

Module	n	At-risk (%)	Withdrawn among at-risk (%)	First deadline	Exam weight (%)	Early score (%)	Median clicks	Aged 35+ (%)
AAA	698	23.9	45.5	0.07	50	98.1	588	52.6
BBB	6,202	39.5	28.0	0.07	50	93.4	224	34.9
CCC	3,191	47.4	48.4	0.07	67	93.1	402	30.3
DDD	4,984	47.7	40.7	0.09	50	93.4	382	26.2
EEE	2,470	33.2	31.6	0.13	50	90.9	586	24.9
FFF	6,289	42.0	35.4	0.08	50	94.5	866	26.2
GGG	2,398	36.9	17.6	0.24	100	53.3	81	39.0

TABLE III

RANKING VERSUS THRESHOLD TRANSFER PER MODULE (25% CUT-OFF, STUDENTS STILL ENROLLED). AUC AND FLAG RATE ($p \geq 0.5$) ARE COMPUTED ON THE STUDENTS OF EACH MODULE; (A) USES OUT-OF-FOLD PREDICTIONS OF THE RANDOM SPLIT, (B) THE MODEL TRAINED ON THE SIX OTHER MODULES.

	Ranking (absolute features)			Flagged students, % (absolute)			Relative features, (B)	
Module	AUC (A)	AUC (B)	Cost	Observed risk	(A)	(B)	AUC	Flagged (%)
AAA	0.733	0.731	+0.002	24	35	45	0.792	37
BBB	0.796	0.753	+0.043	39	37	56	0.801	40
CCC	0.830	0.817	+0.012	47	44	41	0.811	46
DDD	0.837	0.827	+0.010	48	44	39	0.841	39
EEE	0.841	0.838	+0.003	33	26	31	0.837	29
FFF	0.828	0.817	+0.011	42	36	33	0.833	36
GGG	0.739	0.725	+0.014	37	44	95	0.739	30
Mean	0.800	0.787	+0.014	39	38	49	0.808	37

100 labelled students reduces the mean absolute drift from 0.135 to 0.059 and repairs GGG (drift -0.05, precision 0.38 $\rightarrow$ 0.55), but its alert volume varies from one draw of 100 students to another (standard deviation 0.039 of the share flagged), and its mean precision barely moves (0.619 to 0.624). Flagging a fixed share of each cohort (top-q) brings the drift to 0.058 with a precision of 0.631. The relative model reaches the lowest drift (0.043) and the highest precision (0.681) without any label, and the highest F1 (0.659, against 0.647 for Platt and 0.644 for top-q). With a labelled pilot cohort instead of random students, Platt does worse (drift 0.097, precision 0.615), because presentations of a module also differ, whereas the relative model keeps its advantage on the same later presentations (drift 0.067, precision 0.679).

Two qualifications matter. First, against this common reference the relative model *under-flags* GGG (-0.14); but the reference itself over-flags that module, and the distance between the share flagged and the observed at-risk rate is the same for the relative model (0.057) as for the model that has seen the module (0.059), against 0.174 for the raw transferred model and 0.068 for top-q; only the unreachable top-q bound, which knows the true rate of each module, does better (0.003). Second,

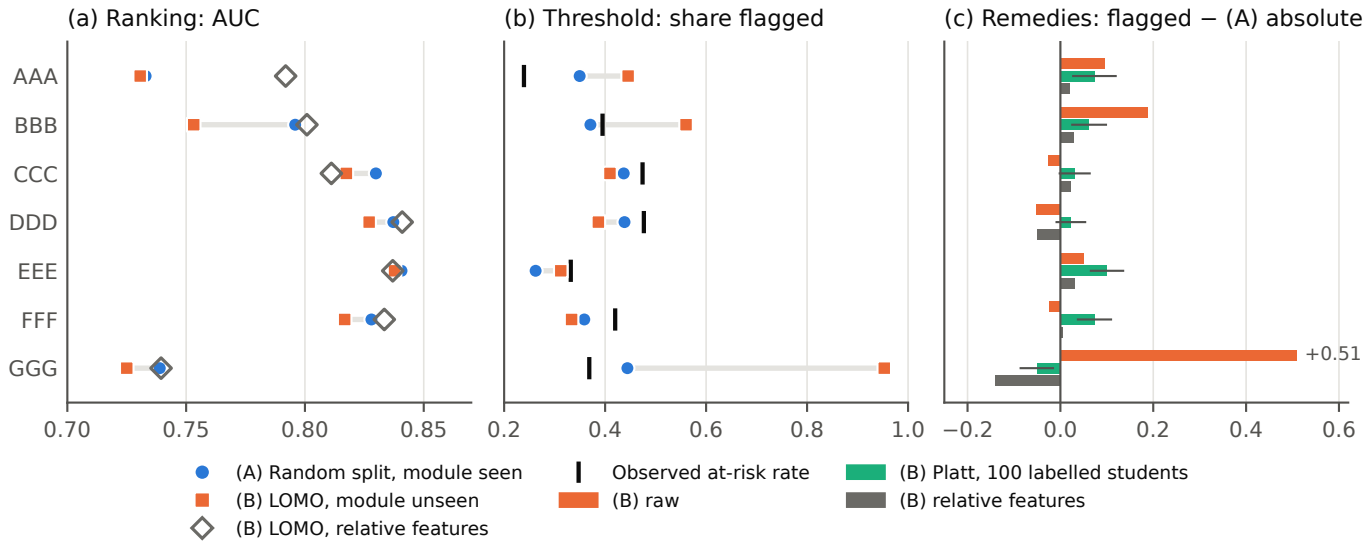


Fig. 2. Ranking versus alert volume per module at the 25% cut-off. (a) AUC when the module is seen (A) or unseen (B), and (B) with relative features. (b) Share of students flagged in (A) and (B) against the observed at-risk rate. (c) Remedies evaluated on the same students and against the same reference, the absolute-feature model with the module seen: share flagged by the raw transferred model, by Platt recalibration on 100 labelled students of the module (mean and standard deviation over 50 draws) and by the relative model, minus the share flagged by the reference.

TABLE IV

CALIBRATION OF THE TRANSFERRED MODEL AT THE 25% CUT-OFF: DIFFERENCE BETWEEN PROTOCOL (B) AND PROTOCOL (A) ON THE SAME STUDENTS, AS THE MEAN ABSOLUTE DIFFERENCE OVER MODULES AND FOR MODULE GGG. BRIER SCORE; CALIBRATION-IN-THE-LARGE (INTERCEPT OF A LOGISTIC RECALIBRATION WITH $\mathrm{logit}(\hat{p})$ AS OFFSET); MEAN PREDICTED RISK; CALIBRATION SLOPE. WITH BALANCED CLASS WEIGHTS THE PROBABILITIES ARE NOT CALIBRATED EVEN IN (A), SO THE TRANSFER EFFECT IS THE DIFFERENCE (B) − (A).

	Brier		Calibration-in-the-large		Mean predicted risk		Slope	
Features	mean $\lvert\Delta\rvert$	GGG	mean $\lvert\Delta\rvert$	GGG	mean $\lvert\Delta\rvert$	GGG	mean $\lvert\Delta\rvert$	GGG
Absolute	0.039	+0.180	0.419	−1.834	0.075	+0.298	0.170	−0.321
Relative	0.006	+0.004	0.079	−0.061	0.015	+0.011	0.077	−0.094

cohort normalization discards the absolute level of engagement in a cohort, which is precisely the information that did not transfer, but which would be needed to detect a cohort that is collectively disengaged.

H. Which normalization, and how large a cohort?

Ranks are not the only way to normalize within the cohort (Table VII). At 25%, a winsorized z-score and a robust standardization reach an AUC of 0.801 and 0.800 on unseen modules, against 0.808 for ranks and 0.787 for absolute values, with a drift of 0.037 and 0.024 against 0.021. Across the three cut-offs tested, the three normalizations differ by at most 0.008 in mean AUC. What matters is to normalize within the cohort; ranks are the best or tied option, have no parameter, and are insensitive to sentinel values and outliers.

Ranks need a cohort of a reasonable size. When they are computed in random sub-cohorts of the target module, the AUC on unseen modules is 0.778, 0.793, 0.802 and 0.805 for 10, 20, 50 and 100 students, against 0.808 with the whole presentation, and the share flagged moves by 0.043, 0.018 and 0.005 from its value with the whole presentation. From about 50 students, ranks are as reliable as with the whole cohort; below 20, the gain degrades sharply, and with 10 students the AUC falls below that of absolute features.

I. Uncertainty and heterogeneity across modules

The differences between relative and absolute features are well estimated for the students of these modules: +0.021 [+0.015, +0.027] in AUC on unseen modules, −0.005 [−0.009, −0.001] in ranking cost, and −0.115 [−0.120, −0.107] in mean absolute drift. They are less uniform across modules. The drift decreases in 6 modules out of seven (Wilcoxon $p = 0.047$); the exception is CCC, whose small drift moves from 0.027 to 0.042. The AUC on unseen modules improves in 5 modules out of seven ($p = 0.078$): the gain is large for AAA (+0.063) and BBB (+0.048), while CCC loses −0.008 and EEE −0.002 (means over 10 seeds). These module-level differences exceed the variability due to the seed, whose standard deviation is at most 0.004 for the AUC of a module and 0.010 for its drift. The mean gains are therefore real for these students, but driven by some modules more than others, and seven modules are too few to generalize them.

The strict protocol matters little on average: keeping the students also enrolled in the held-out module changes the mean AUC on unseen modules by at most 0.003 across cut-offs and feature sets. It matters for the modules that share many students: with absolute features, removing these students changes the AUC of CCC by −0.007 and of EEE by −0.006, whereas removing the same number of randomly chosen enrolments

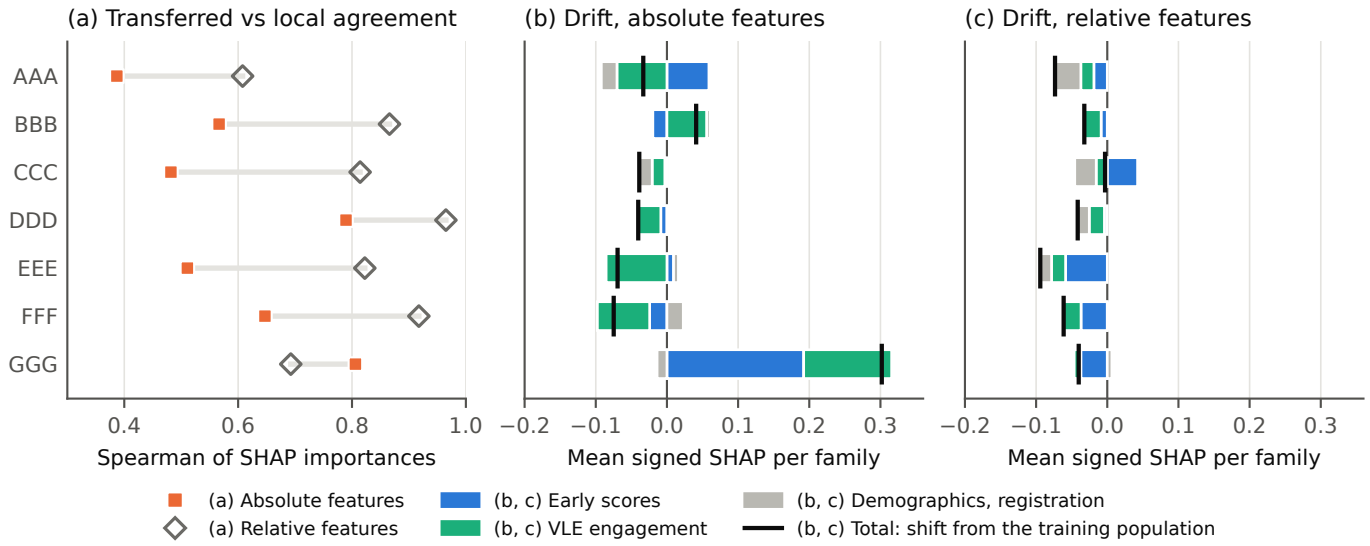


Fig. 3. Same features, wrong scales (25% cut-off). (a) Spearman correlation between the SHAP importances of the transferred model and of a model trained on the module itself. (b, c) Mean signed SHAP attribution of the transferred model on the students of each module, by feature family: the shift of their predicted risk from the training population.

TABLE V
CONTEXT DESCRIPTORS ASSOCIATED WITH THE THREE TRANSFER AXES (SPEARMAN'S ρ, BENJAMINI–HOCHBERG $q < 0.10$ WITHIN LEVEL, 69 TESTS IN TOTAL). MOD.: MODULES; PRES.: PRESENTATIONS, WHICH ARE NOT INDEPENDENT (THEY SHARE THE MODULE-LEVEL LOMO MODEL). DIFFICULTY: AUC (A); RANK. COST: AUC (A) − AUC (B); DRIFT: FLAG-RATE DRIFT. EXPLORATORY ASSOCIATIONS.

Level (n)	Axis	Descriptor	ρ	q
Mod. (7)	Difficulty	Share aged 35+	−0.96	0.016
Pres. (22)	Difficulty	Share aged 35+	−0.79	0.000
Pres. (22)	Difficulty	VLE activity types	+0.54	0.037
Pres. (22)	Difficulty	At-risk rate	+0.49	0.060
Pres. (22)	Rank. cost	Assessments due before cut-off	+0.57	0.030
Pres. (22)	Rank. cost	First deadline	−0.45	0.097
Pres. (22)	Drift	Withdrawn share among at-risk	−0.68	0.008
Pres. (22)	Drift	Share aged 35+	+0.64	0.015
Pres. (22)	Drift	At-risk rate	−0.61	0.023
Pres. (22)	Drift	Median clicks	−0.59	0.028
Pres. (22)	Drift	Share without A-level	+0.56	0.033
Pres. (22)	Drift	Assessment-structure distance	+0.52	0.048
Pres. (22)	Drift	VLE activity types	−0.51	0.048
Pres. (22)	Drift	Assessments due before cut-off	−0.44	0.099

changes it by +0.001 and −0.001. The standard protocol thus credits the model with recognizing students it has already seen, which is why we use the strict one.

J. Fairness

Table VIII and Fig. 4 report error-rate gaps between groups. With absolute features, transfer creates a gender gap that does not exist when modules are seen: the FPR gap between women and men moves from −0.007 [−0.019, +0.005] in (A) to +0.194 [+0.180, +0.208] in (B). Yet within modules, the transferred model's FPR is never significantly higher for women, and it is significantly lower in 5 modules out of seven (Fig. 4c). The pooled gap is a composition effect: women make up 88% of BBB and 81% of GGG, the two modules whose alert volume drifts upwards, so the drift of these modules is attributed to gender when modules are pooled [26]. With relative features, the pooled gap is strongly attenuated, to +0.015 [+0.003, +0.026]; it is reduced, not eliminated, and within modules the largest gap, in CCC (+0.035 [−0.014, +0.081]), is not significant.

IMD and disability gaps behave differently. They exist under every protocol and reflect different base rates (51% at risk in Q1 against 33% in Q5): the most deprived students are flagged more often, correctly and incorrectly (FPR gap +0.148 in (A), +0.156 in (B)). Unlike the gender gap, the IMD gap is present within courses: the FPR of Q1 is significantly higher in 5 modules out of seven. Relative features reduce the pooled FPR gap in (B) by −0.039 [−0.064, −0.017] without closing it, consistent with the impossibility of equalizing error rates and calibration when base rates differ [23], [24].

K. Sequences and other learners

Table IX and Fig. 5 repeat the analysis with gradient boosting and the GRU. Temporal information adds little to early prediction: on unseen modules with relative features, adding weekly sequences and trends to gradient boosting raises AUC by at most 0.005 across cut-offs, and the GRU exceeds the forest by 0.006 to 0.008. At these windows, the aggregated counts already carry most of the early signal.

The calibration problem, in contrast, does not depend on the learner. With absolute features, all four models drift by 0.127 to 0.137 on average at 25%, and GGG by +0.47 to +0.53. Relative features reduce the drift for every model, to 0.015 for the GRU, which also has the smallest ranking cost (0.003), and to 0.051 for gradient boosting, whose residual drift is spread over modules with alternating signs rather than concentrated

TABLE VI

REMEDIES COMPARED ON THE SAME STUDENTS AND AGAINST THE SAME REFERENCE (25% CUT-OFF). FOR EACH MODULE, ALL RULES ARE EVALUATED ON THE STUDENTS NOT DRAWN FOR PLATT RECALIBRATION ($k = 100$ LABELLED STUDENTS OF THE TARGET MODULE, MEAN OF 50 DRAWS; STANDARD DEVIATION ACROSS DRAWS IN PARENTHESES). DRIFT: SHARE FLAGGED MINUS THAT OF THE ABSOLUTE-FEATURE MODEL TRAINED WITH THE MODULE SEEN, (A). RAW: ABSOLUTE FEATURES, THRESHOLD 0.5. TOP-q: IN EACH COHORT, THE q STUDENTS WITH THE HIGHEST SCORES, q BEING THE AT-RISK RATE OF THE SIX TRAINING MODULES. RELATIVE: CONTEXT-RELATIVE FEATURES, THRESHOLD 0.5. PLATT AND THE RAW MODEL USE ABSOLUTE FEATURES; ONLY PLATT USES LABELS OF THE TARGET MODULE.

	Flag-rate drift vs (A)				Precision			
Module	Raw	Platt-k	Top-q	Relative	Raw	Platt-k	Top-q	Relative
AAA	+0.10	+0.07 (0.05)	+0.07	+0.02	0.38	0.39	0.38	0.45
BBB	+0.19	+0.06 (0.04)	+0.05	+0.03	0.54	0.60	0.61	0.67
CCC	−0.03	+0.03 (0.03)	−0.02	+0.02	0.78	0.74	0.77	0.72
DDD	−0.05	+0.02 (0.03)	−0.04	−0.05	0.79	0.75	0.78	0.81
EEE	+0.05	+0.10 (0.04)	+0.15	+0.03	0.70	0.66	0.60	0.72
FFF	−0.03	+0.07 (0.04)	+0.05	+0.01	0.76	0.69	0.70	0.76
GGG	+0.51	−0.05 (0.04)	−0.03	−0.14	0.38	0.55	0.56	0.64
Mean $\lvert\cdot\rvert$ / mean	0.14	0.06	0.06	0.04	0.62	0.62	0.63	0.68
Mean $\lvert$flagged − risk$\rvert$	0.17	0.06	0.07	0.06		(A) absolute: 0.06		

TABLE VII

WHICH COHORT NORMALIZATION, AND HOW LARGE A COHORT? TOP: NORMALIZATION OF THE EIGHT ENGAGEMENT AND EARLY-ASSESSMENT FEATURES WITHIN EACH PRESENTATION (25% CUT-OFF, LOMO STRICT, MEANS OVER MODULES). DRIFT: MEAN ABSOLUTE FLAG-RATE DRIFT (B) − (A) OF THE SAME VARIANT; $\lvert$FLAGGED − RISK$\rvert$: DISTANCE BETWEEN THE SHARE FLAGGED IN (B) AND THE OBSERVED AT-RISK RATE. BOTTOM: AUC (B) OF THE RANK MODEL WHEN RANKS ARE COMPUTED IN RANDOM SUB-COHORTS OF n STUDENTS OF THE TARGET MODULE (5 RANDOM PARTITIONS); WITH THE WHOLE PRESENTATION: 0.808.

Normalization	AUC (A)	AUC (B)	Cost	Drift	$\lvert$flagged − risk$\rvert$	Precision (B)	F1 (B)
Absolute values	0.800	0.787	+0.014	0.135	0.174	0.618	0.637
Percentile rank	0.816	0.808	+0.008	0.021	0.057	0.680	0.658
z-score (winsorized 1–99%)	0.814	0.801	+0.014	0.037	0.061	0.666	0.653
Robust (median, IQR)	0.809	0.800	+0.009	0.024	0.054	0.664	0.648
Cohort size n (AUC (B)) — 10: 0.778; 20: 0.793; 50: 0.802; 100: 0.805; 200: 0.806							

TABLE VIII

BETWEEN-GROUP GAPS IN ERROR RATES AT THE 25% CUT-OFF (THRESHOLD 0.5), WITH 95% CONFIDENCE INTERVALS FROM A STUDENT-LEVEL CLUSTER BOOTSTRAP (1,000 RESAMPLES). TPR: RECALL; FPR: FALSE-POSITIVE RATE; PPV: PRECISION; FLAG: SHARE OF STUDENTS FLAGGED.

Contrast	Configuration	TPR gap	FPR gap	PPV gap	Flag-rate gap
Female − male	(A) absolute	−0.080 [−0.096, −0.061]	−0.007 [−0.019, +0.005]	−0.042 [−0.058, −0.025]	−0.050 [−0.062, −0.038]
	(B) absolute	+0.018 [+0.001, +0.035]	+0.194 [+0.180, +0.208]	−0.173 [−0.189, −0.155]	+0.111 [+0.099, +0.123]
	(B) relative	−0.065 [−0.082, −0.047]	+0.015 [+0.003, +0.026]	−0.060 [−0.077, −0.043]	−0.031 [−0.043, −0.020]
IMD Q1 − Q5	(A) absolute	+0.135 [+0.104, +0.165]	+0.148 [+0.127, +0.169]	+0.044 [+0.013, +0.077]	+0.224 [+0.205, +0.243]
	(B) absolute	+0.145 [+0.115, +0.175]	+0.156 [+0.132, +0.180]	+0.111 [+0.080, +0.142]	+0.219 [+0.200, +0.239]
	(B) relative	+0.125 [+0.095, +0.157]	+0.116 [+0.096, +0.137]	+0.062 [+0.032, +0.094]	+0.205 [+0.186, +0.226]
Disability yes − no	(A) absolute	+0.095 [+0.067, +0.121]	+0.102 [+0.076, +0.128]	+0.020 [−0.006, +0.047]	+0.146 [+0.124, +0.167]
	(B) absolute	+0.050 [+0.025, +0.074]	+0.111 [+0.083, +0.139]	+0.036 [+0.011, +0.064]	+0.121 [+0.099, +0.140]
	(B) relative	+0.078 [+0.051, +0.105]	+0.060 [+0.034, +0.085]	+0.045 [+0.020, +0.072]	+0.117 [+0.094, +0.138]

in one design. The mechanism identified with the forest is a property of the features, not of the learner.

L. Robustness to the target definition

Restricted to students still enrolled at the cut-off, "Withdrawn only" becomes *future* withdrawal, a rarer (13.7% at 25%) and harder target (Table X). At the 0.5 threshold, the balanced forest rarely flags such students (recall 0.12 in (B)), so we compare on AUC. The pattern holds: relative features lower the ranking cost from 0.028 to 0.012, the mean absolute drift from 0.054 to 0.028 (GGG: +0.17 to +0.03), and raise LOMO AUC from 0.623 to 0.662.

V. DISCUSSION

A. What transfers and what does not

Our results draw a sharper picture of model portability than an accuracy gap. The ordering of students by risk is largely shared across modules: early scores, recent activity and the number of submissions predict risk everywhere, as local models confirm. What is specific to a course is the scale on which these signals are expressed: how many clicks a normal week requires, when the first assessment is due, whether early assignments are graded. A model that learns absolute thresholds carries the scale of its training courses into the new one, and its probabilities are miscalibrated there. The parallel with clinical prediction

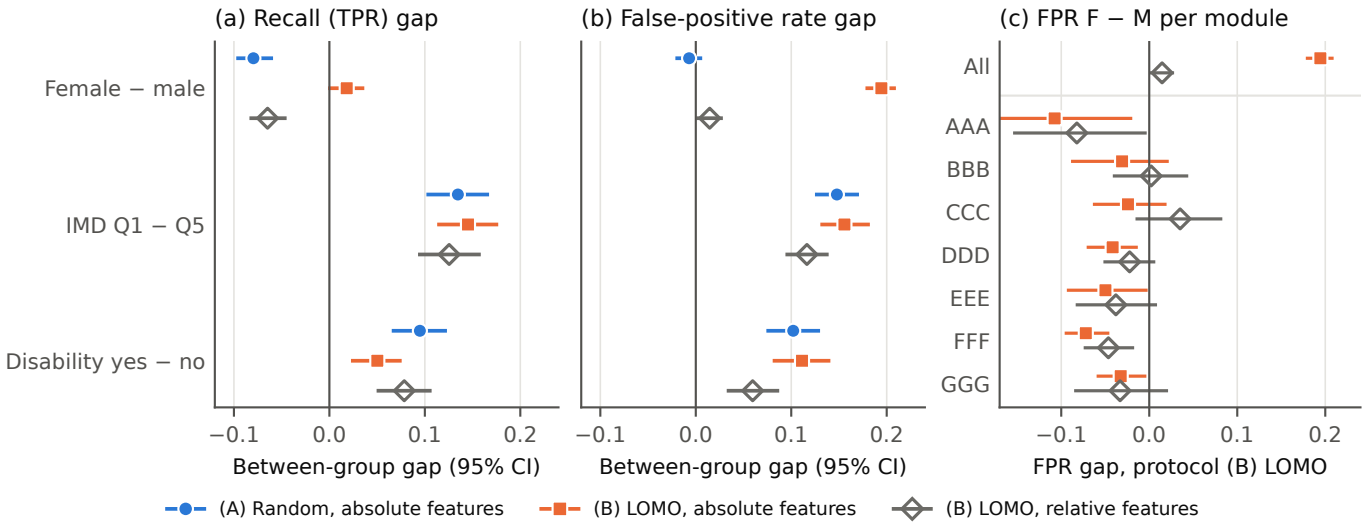


Fig. 4. Error-rate gaps between groups (25% cut-off, 95% cluster-bootstrap intervals). (a) Recall and (b) false-positive rate gaps. (c) Female–male FPR gap of the transferred model within each module and over all modules, with absolute and relative features: the pooled gap of the absolute model is a composition effect.

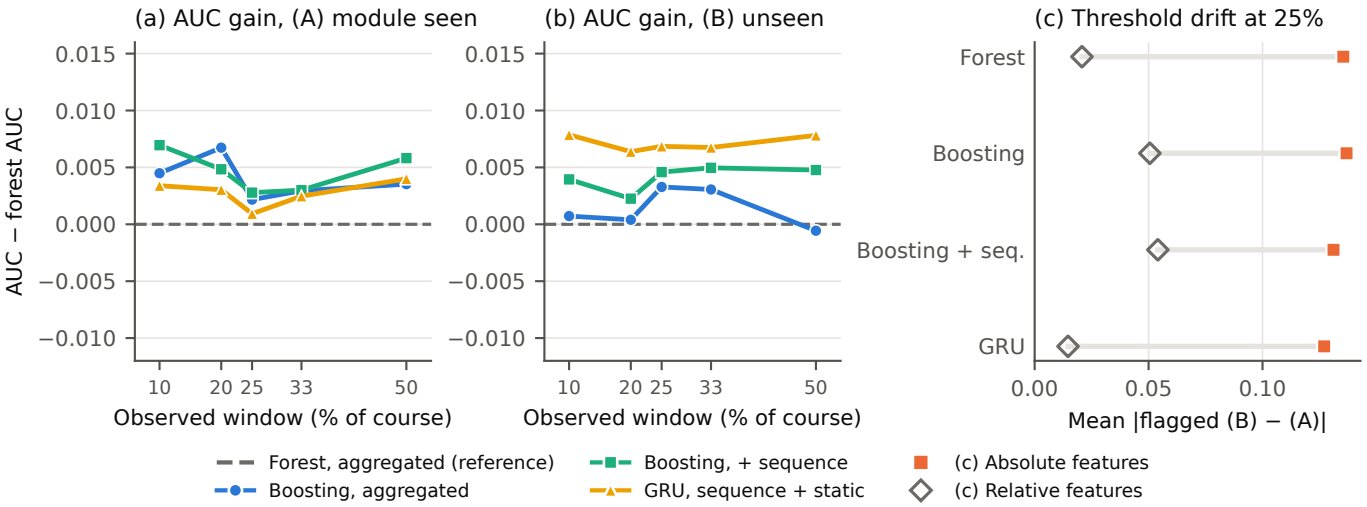


Fig. 5. Sequences and other learners (students still enrolled). (a, b) AUC gain over the aggregated random forest (dashed zero line) with relative features, when the module is seen (A) or unseen (B). (c) Mean absolute flag-rate drift at the 25% cut-off with absolute and relative features.

models, where discrimination travels better than calibration [15], [16], is close, and so are the remedies.

These conclusions have three levels of support. The gains of cohort normalization are established for the students of the seven modules studied, with confidence intervals that exclude zero, but they are uneven across modules and one module, CCC, is slightly worse off. The interpretation that normalization reduces sensitivity to course design is supported by the mechanism, the SHAP decomposition and the consistency across learners. Transfer across institutions or countries is not tested here.

B. Implications for deployment in a new context

For an institution starting an early-warning system without labelled history, four practical recommendations follow. First, normalize engagement and early-assessment features within the cohort at the prediction date. This needs no outcome data, only a cohort observed up to the same day, and a cohort of at least about 50 students; smaller groups should be pooled, for instance across sections or sessions of the same course. Second, monitor the alert volume against expectations from the first weeks: a flag rate far from the expected risk is a sign of miscalibration, not of an at-risk cohort. Third, once a first cohort is labelled, recalibrate, keeping in mind that recalibration on about a hundred students varies from one sample to another. Fourth, decide how alerts are used before deploying them. Since gaps linked to deprivation and disability persist within courses and cannot all be removed when base rates differ, alerts should trigger an offer of support reviewed by a person, not an automatic decision, and their distribution across groups should be monitored.

TABLE IX
MODEL FAMILIES AND TEMPORAL INFORMATION AT THE 25% CUT-OFF (STUDENTS STILL ENROLLED; MEANS OVER MODULES). FOREST AND BOOSTING: AGGREGATED FEATURES; BOOSTING + SEQ.: AGGREGATED FEATURES PLUS WEEKLY CLICKS AND ACTIVE DAYS OVER THE COMPLETE WEEKS BEFORE THE CUT-OFF AND TREND FEATURES; GRU: RECURRENT NETWORK ON THE WEEKLY SEQUENCE PLUS ALL STATIC FEATURES. COST: AUC (A) − AUC (B); DRIFT: MEAN ABSOLUTE FLAG-RATE DRIFT; GGG: DRIFT IN MODULE GGG.

Features	Model	AUC (A)	AUC (B)	Cost	Drift	GGG
Absolute	Forest	0.800	0.787	+0.014	0.135	+0.51
	Boosting	0.805	0.787	+0.018	0.137	+0.53
	Boosting + seq.	0.808	0.791	+0.017	0.131	+0.52
	GRU	0.799	0.792	+0.007	0.127	+0.47
Relative	Forest	0.816	0.808	+0.008	0.021	+0.00
	Boosting	0.818	0.811	+0.007	0.051	+0.01
	Boosting + seq.	0.819	0.812	+0.007	0.054	+0.02
	GRU	0.817	0.815	+0.003	0.015	+0.00

TABLE X
ROBUSTNESS TO THE TARGET DEFINITION (25% CUT-OFF, STUDENTS STILL ENROLLED; MEANS OVER MODULES). W OR F: WITHDRAWN OR FAIL; W ONLY: WITHDRAWN ONLY. ABS./REL.: ABSOLUTE OR RELATIVE FEATURES. COST: AUC (A) − AUC (B); DRIFT: MEAN ABSOLUTE FLAG-RATE DRIFT.

Target	Feat.	Risk (%)	AUC (A)	AUC (B)	Cost	Drift	GGG
W or F	abs.	38.7	0.800	0.787	+0.014	0.135	+0.51
W or F	rel.	38.7	0.816	0.808	+0.008	0.021	+0.00
W only	abs.	13.7	0.651	0.623	+0.028	0.054	+0.17
W only	rel.	13.7	0.675	0.662	+0.012	0.028	+0.03

C. Implications for evaluation practice

Five lessons generalize beyond OULAD. Early-prediction studies should restrict the population to students still enrolled at the prediction date and check leakage by invariance, not only by excluding outcome variables. Course-level hold-out should exclude students enrolled in the held-out course from training, as random splits group by student. Comparisons between protocols must use the same aggregation. Alert rates and calibration metrics should be reported alongside discrimination, since recall alone rewards over-flagging. Fairness audits that pool contexts should be complemented by within-context audits; otherwise a calibration problem can read as discrimination and, conversely, a real within-context bias can be masked by composition.

D. Limitations

The study uses one institution and seven modules; module-level tests have little power, presentation-level correlations are not independent, and our bootstrap intervals cover the sampling of students, not of courses. The threshold is fixed at 0.5 with balanced class weights; we checked that the drift persists from 0.3 to 0.7 and in calibration metrics, and compared it with flagging a fixed share of each cohort, which fixes the alert volume by construction but leaves that share to be set for each new course. Gradient boosting and a GRU confirm the mechanism, but our GRU is deliberately small and richer event streams might extract more temporal signal. SHAP values are estimated from a subsample of trees and 400 students per module. Cohort normalization removes between-cohort differences in the level of engagement, so a model using it cannot detect a whole cohort that is collectively disengaged, and it needs cohorts of about 50 students or more. IMD and disability gaps remain within courses and call for policy choices on how alerts are used. Finally, the transfer we study is between modules of one university; transfer across institutions and countries, which motivates this work, remains to be tested.

E. Future work

We will replay the same protocol on Moodle data from a fully online Senegalese university, where the held-out context becomes a degree programme and then a country, and study whether cohort normalization also stabilizes transfer across institutions whose VLE usage differs more than between modules of one university.

VI. CONCLUSION

Measured strictly—early, on students still enrolled, with no student on both sides of the split and with comparable aggregation—the cost of moving an at-risk model to an unseen course is small for ranking and large for alert volume and calibration. Calibration fails because engagement and early scores are read on absolute scales that depend on course design; the same features matter everywhere. Normalizing them within the cohort reduces the drift without labels, improves ranking on unseen courses on average, and strongly attenuates a gender disparity created by pooling contexts, provided cohorts are large enough. Early-warning systems meant to travel should be evaluated on unseen contexts, report alert rates and calibration alongside discrimination, and audit fairness within contexts.

DATA AND CODE AVAILABILITY

OULAD is available under a CC-BY 4.0 licence from the Open University (https://analyse.kmi.open.ac.uk/open_dataset). The code that reproduces every figure, table and number of this article, with its tests, is available at https://github.com/duducolydev/analyses_oualad.

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